led an experimental team before in his life. Heisenberg's team worked on creating a controlled nuclear chain reaction up until the end of the war in 1945, unaware that Fermi had already done it in Chicago in 1942—and unable to prevent a nuclear meltdown should they succeed and lose control of the reaction. Indeed, Heisenberg had much less control than he thought: he hoped to "make use of warfare for physics" by doing interesting nuclear physics research with the blood money he received from the Nazi regime—even if that research handed Hitler nuclear power. Heisenberg "had agreed to sup with the devil," wrote Peierls years later, "and perhaps he found that there was not a long enough spoon."

By December 1944, it was clear to Heisenberg that Germany was near defeat—speaking with his colleague Gregor Wentzel at a dinner party in Switzerland, he wistfully sighed that "it would have been so beautiful if we had won." He returned to his fission lab in Hechingen and made one last push to complete the reactor, but he was out of time. In April 1945, with the Allies closing in on Germany from all sides, Heisenberg was forced to flee from his research. He bicycled 250 kilometers in seventy-two hours, moving only at night so he wouldn't be shot by Allied aircraft, and made his way to his family in Urfeld. Days later, he was apprehended there by an American military task force, Operation Alsos, that had been sent deep into Europe to capture and interrogate the German nuclear physicists.

The Alsos team whisked off Heisenberg, Hahn, von Laue, and several other German physicists to Farm Hall, an English manor house that had been converted into a military intelligence post. The house was supplied with sporting equipment, chalkboards, a radio, and plenty of food—more comforts than the average English family, grumbled one of their military minders. The average English family certainly didn't have Farm Hall's full complement of hidden microphones in each room. "I wonder whether there are microphones installed here?" asked Kurt Diebner, one of the German physicists, several days after their arrival. "Microphones installed?" replied Heisenberg, laughing. "Oh no, they're not as cute as all that. I don't think they know the real Gestapo methods; they're a bit old fashioned in that respect." Reassured, the German physicists freely discussed physics, politics, and current events, eagerly reading the newspapers that their British minders had supplied in the express hope of provoking discussion.

Heisenberg and the others also discussed the mystery of their continued